



to the IPL from 2009. It will now factor in this playing commitment when managing the workloads of its players.

It is not only players that will be the beneficiaries. Support staff, coaches, physios, trainers, event managers, and so on will now have similar opportunities to supplement their home-based incomes. I see this outcome as especially important to cricket as it means that very good professionals can be attracted and retained into the game for longer period.

At the same time, the IPL will also need to learn lessons from English county cricket where overseas players and support staff have been journeying since the early 1900s, but increasingly so in the last 40 years. Ostensibly, the players and coaches were not only there to greatly assist performance on the field, but also to leave a legacy, a learning experience for all those who were to be educated into the different methods and practices that these overseas professionals brought with them. My view is

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that in county cricket, the majority of overseas recruits lined their pockets first, then played for themselves and the ability or desire to leave a long-term legacy ran a distant last. Hopefully, this will not be the case with the IPL. Whatever be the outcome from the debates revolving around IPL over the next six to nine months, it is certain that the league is here to stay, and that, an increasingly discerning market will be demanding more and more value for its rupee in the next season.

This year the franchises and the IPL organisers ventured into the tournament with little preparation time. Though the event has been an unmitigated success, with a longer lead-in time, better planning, and a year's experience, everyone will be in better shape for 2009. The coming years will be more demanding on players, coaches, administrators and those who produce the league, simply because the honeymoon will be over. Not even valid reasons for a lack of success will be tolerated. So, be ready or beware. ■

UNITED COLOURS OF IPL: There will be more foreign players in IPL's next season